

Integrated Design Practice: A reflection on combining Animation, Visual Effects & Game Design for first year undergraduate students

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Abstract

This paper reflects on the transition from the legacy Digital Design major to the Animation, Visual Effects, and Game Design (AVG) degree at Auckland University of Technology (AUT). It examines how first-year papers DESN511 and DESN512 support student engagement and pathway selection through inclusive, interdisciplinary, and culturally grounded teaching. Students explore animation, VFX, and game design through hands-on, concept-led projects that centre identity, storytelling, and experimentation. Activities such as collaborative storytelling and tactile self-portraiture foster connection and inclusion, aligning with Mātauranga Māori and the Bachelor of Design's educational philosophy. These experiences help students feel seen and supported, with reflective annotations and anecdotal feedback indicating increased confidence and clarity in creative direction. The paper also addresses challenges including cohort growth, neurodiversity, and staffing needs, proposing scalable strategies that balance foundational skill development with creative freedom. Animation is positioned as a shared language across disciplines, while VFX and game design offer entry points into narrative and interactive expression. By embedding writing into creative practice and fostering a culture of reflection, the AVG curriculum supports identity formation and interdisciplinary fluency, contributing to broader conversations about inclusive and future-focused design education.

CCS Concepts

• Applied computing; • Education; Computer Games; • Computing methodologies; • Computer graphics; Animation;

Keywords

education, curriculum design, animation, visual effects, game design

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1 Introduction

This paper reflects on the transition from the former Digital Design major to the current Animation, Visual Effects, and Game Design (AVG) major at Auckland University of Technology (AUT). It examines how DESN511 and DESN512 influence students' pathway choices across animation, VFX, and game design, while also addressing challenges such as growing cohort sizes and increasing staffing needs¹.

The restructuring of the degree signals a broader commitment to decolonising education and embracing Indigenous Māori thinking. Central to this is the principle of *ako*, which emphasises reciprocal teaching and learning relationships. This approach challenges traditional Western models by recognising diverse ways of constructing and sharing knowledge. Such principles are increasingly reflected in national education initiatives, including *Activating Aotearoa Histories*, which positions *ako* as central to culturally responsive and equity-focused pedagogy (Berryman et al., 2025).

AUT's design curriculum responds to the changing landscape of creative careers by integrating Mātauranga Māori², interdisciplinary collaboration, and emergent technologies. Within this framework, DESN511 and DESN512 foster environments where students develop creative and critical thinking skills through project-based learning. This aligns with global best practices, including findings from a systematic review of 187 studies (Mariela et al., 2025), which highlight interdisciplinary approaches as key to nurturing creativity in higher education.

As Welby Ings, 2017 notes, creative thinking can be cultivated through intentional and reflective pedagogy. Educators play a vital role in designing learning experiences that promote inquiry, experimentation, and reflection, encouraging students to question norms and engage deeply with their educational journey. By prompting students to consider what they are learning and why, we support the emergence of creative identities grounded in cultural awareness and intellectual independence. Written content is now embedded within creative practice papers, shifting away from standalone essays. Students produce focused annotations and reflections tied

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¹AVG refers to Animation, Visual Effects, & Game Design as pathways through this degree program. Students choose which pathway they will follow after their first semester of study.

²Mātauranga Māori reflects a Māori way of being and engaging in the world. At its core, it draws on *kawa* (cultural practices) and *tikanga* (cultural principles) to critique, examine, analyse and understand the world.

Year 1		Year 2		Year 3	
Semester 1	Semester 2	Semester 1	Semester 2	Semester 1	Semester 2
AVG Mahitahi Collaborative Practices DESN511 Introduction to Design Practice DESN512 Making & Media	AVG Major Course <i>Chosen Pathway</i> Animation, Visual Effects, Game + Two minors or Second major or One minor + elective course	AVG Major Course <i>Chosen Pathway</i> Animation, Visual Effects, Game + Two minors or Second major or One minor + elective course	AVG Major Course <i>Chosen Pathway</i> Animation, Visual Effects, Game + Two minors or Second major or One minor + elective course	AVG Major Course <i>Chosen Pathway</i> Animation, Visual Effects, Game + Two minors or Second major or One minor + elective course	AVG Major Course <i>Chosen Pathway</i> Animation, Visual Effects, Game Design Final capstone project ~ Personal brief

Figure 1: Overview of the AVG undergraduate structure

directly to their projects, reinforcing personal authorship and critical engagement, particularly relevant in an era shaped by generative AI.

2 Reflection on introductory course

DESN511 Introduction to Design Practice and DESN512 Making and Media are foundational Level 5 papers that serve as key entry points for students transitioning into the Animation, Visual Effects, and Game Design (AVG) major (Figure 1) in the second semester. These papers are part of a cross-disciplinary framework within the Art and Design faculty at AUT, designed so that any student can engage with introductory design concepts that are applicable across a range of specialisations. While open to all pathways, the AVG-facing delivery of these papers introduces methods and tools that are directly relevant to animation, visual effects, and game design practice. Students are introduced to core design principles and creative technologies through project-based learning that is both culturally grounded and technically exploratory. Shared learning resources such as colour theory³, preproduction planning⁴, and visual storytelling are embedded across both papers, supporting interdisciplinary engagement and skill development.

In DESN511, the project is framed by the The Māori whakatauki (proverb) “Ko te wai te ora o ngā mea katoa” (Water is the life giver of all things), encouraging students to reflect on their own cultural backgrounds and how these influence their design decisions.⁵ Students create a short film that explores the relationship

between a chosen water source⁶, a nostalgic object, and their identity. This project integrates stop motion animation and green screen compositing, allowing students to explore narrative construction through visual media while engaging with themes of place, whakapapa⁷, and belonging. The Waihorotiu⁸ hikoi⁹ with Grayson Goffe (OurAuckland, n.d.) provides a tangible connection to local history and environment, which informs the students’ final films and deepens their understanding of cultural context.

In DESN512, students create an interactive collage in Unity 3D¹⁰, based on a pivotal moment from their life, culture, or identity. This assignment introduces basic Unity workflows, interaction design, and animation principles, encouraging students to connect storytelling with digital media in a hands-on, exploratory way. The animation component is directly tied to the story, prompting students to consider the reasoning behind what they make and how it communicates meaning. While coding is not required, students gain exposure to the logic behind interactive systems, learning how visual and technical elements combine to support narrative expression. This active approach to software learning reinforces the connection between story, culture, and identity, and supports the development of creative confidence and technical fluency.

Both these papers share resources that can be applied to each other (Figure 2).

³Colour theory in film, games, animation, and VFX enhances storytelling, mood, and audience engagement. Film can use colour for emotion and theme; games for guidance and immersion; animation for expression and style; and VFX for realism or fantasy. Key principles include contrast, harmony, colour schemes, temperature, and saturation.
⁴Preproduction planning is the initial phase where all creative, technical, and logistical elements are organised before production begins. It can include scriptwriting, budgeting, scheduling, casting, concept design, location scouting, and technical setup.
⁵The Waihorotiu Stream (pronounced Why-ho-ro-tee-oo) is a stream in Auckland, New Zealand. Its Māori name, Wai Horotiu, means ‘Horotiu’s water’. This stream used to flow openly down the main street of Auckland, Queen Street. Today, it is hidden underground.

⁶Water sources for this context can be fixed water sources, such as a specific lake or stream. It can also be a more abstracted non-fixed water source, such as tears and rainwater.
⁷Whakapapa is a Māori concept of genealogy that connects people to their ancestors, land, and the natural world. It defines identity, belonging, and relationships, forming the foundation of Māori knowledge and worldview.
⁸Te Waihorotiu, also known as Waihorotiu Stream, is a stream that flowed through central Auckland, New Zealand. Waihorotiu was an important waterway for the local iwi (tribes), providing food, bathing, ceremonial resources, and supporting papakāinga (settlements) along its banks. It was later buried and built over during colonial development.
⁹A hikoi is a Māori term for a protest march or journey, often organized to raise awareness, express grievances, or advocate for social and political change.
¹⁰Unity is a popular game engine used to create 2D, 3D, AR, and VR experiences. It offers tools for real-time editing, scripting, and cross-platform deployment, making it widely used in games, animation, and interactive media.

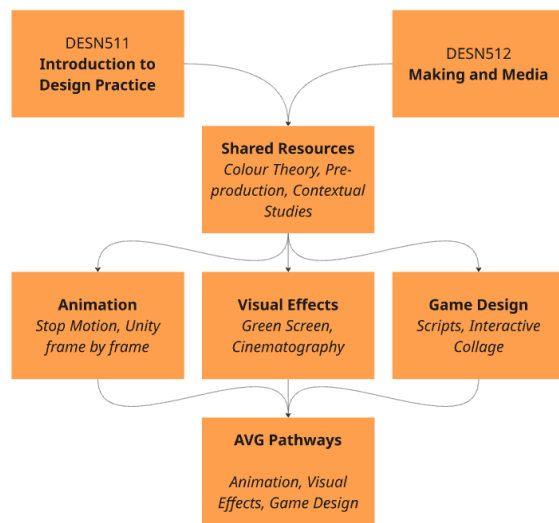


Figure 2: Diagram of the flow of knowledge within AVG

2.1 Animation as a Foundational Language in the AVG Curriculum

Animation is introduced early in the AVG curriculum as a shared language that bridges the disciplines of animation, visual effects, and game design. In DESN511 and DESN512, students engage with both physical and digital animation practices, gaining foundational experience that supports their progression into more specialised areas.

In DESN511, students create stop motion animations¹¹ of nostalgic objects¹², which are composited into live-action short films. This creative process is framed by thematic explorations of identity and place, with Māori perspectives embedded through the narrative focus on Wai Horotiu, the hidden river beneath Auckland. Foundational exercises, such as the bouncing ball¹³, are used to introduce core principles of movement and timing, reinforcing animation's role as a tool for cultural expression and emotional resonance.

In DESN512, students shift into digital animation using Unity, allowing them to animate puppets quickly and creatively. These animations form part of interactive collage projects, where students explore interactive design and storytelling. The contrast between physical and digital workflows provides diverse learning experiences and a broad understanding of animation's expressive potential.

¹¹Stop motion animation is a medium where physical objects are moved in small increments and photographed frame by frame. With this, it will create the illusion of movement when played in sequence.

¹²In this context, a nostalgic object is an item that can be manipulated/animated and should personally connect the designer to the work. The stop-motion segment must feature this object, which is either an existing item with sentimental value or a newly created one that is well-justified (such as the original being lost or too fragile). The emphasis is on the personal meaning of the object, not the complexity of its creation.

¹³Students are prompted to create a short bouncing ball animation. They are introduced to the principles of animation relevant to this context, such as squash and stretch, overlapping action and arcs. The exercise allows them to be introduced into patience as an animator, the importance of planning and building a critical eye for illusion of motion.

Across both courses, animation is positioned not only as a technical skill but as a medium for storytelling, identity exploration, and interactive engagement.

2.2 Visual Effects (VFX) as a Gateway to visual storytelling

Visual effects (VFX) are introduced to provide students with practical exposure to visual storytelling and compositing. In DESN511, students engage with greenscreen techniques, cinematography, and camera work as part of their short film projects. The use of greenscreen¹⁴ not only enhances the visual narrative but also encourages students to consider spatial relationships and layering within their compositions. Additionally, students develop the technical skills required to chroma key effectively using Adobe After Effects, gaining hands-on experience in digital post-production¹⁵.

In DESN512, VFX practices are extended through digital workflows using tools such as Photoshop¹⁶, Premiere¹⁷, and After Effects¹⁸. Students learn to composite animated puppets and interactive elements into their Unity-based interactive collages, building on foundational cinematographic principles introduced in DESN511. This progression allows students to explore the expressive potential of VFX in both linear and interactive formats, reinforcing its role in crafting immersive, culturally resonant experiences.

By engaging with both physical and digital VFX techniques, students develop a nuanced understanding of how visual effects contribute to storytelling, emotional tone, and audience engagement. These experiences lay the groundwork for more advanced compositing and post-production practices in later stages of the AVG pathway.

2.3 Game Design as a framework for interactive expression

Students are introduced to game design principles in DESN512 through the interactive collage project, an assessment carried over from the previous Digital Design curriculum. Based on a pivotal moment selected by the student and connected to their personal life, identity or cultural background, the collage is realised through animated imagery, audio, and lightweight interactivity. This approach prioritises storytelling and creative development over technical complexity, aligning with a broader shift in art and design education toward culturally responsive and inclusive practice.

As Peng and Kueh, 2022 argue, integrating design thinking with cultural intelligence (CQ) fosters empathy, cross-cultural awareness, and meaningful engagement in socially complex environments. Utilising Unity 3D and premade scripts, the assessment lowers

¹⁴Green screen, also known as chroma-keying, is a technique where a green background is replaced digitally with another image or scene in post-production, enabling visual effects and virtual environments.

¹⁵Post-production is the stage after filming or creating content (production), where editing, visual effects, sound design, colour grading, and final adjustments are made to complete the project.

¹⁶Photoshop is an image editing software, widely used in VFX for creating and enhancing visual elements. It can be used for digital painting, texture creation, matte painting, compositing, and photo manipulation.

¹⁷Adobe Premiere is a professional video editing software used to cut, arrange, and enhance video footage.

¹⁸Adobe After Effects is a motion graphics and visual effects software used to create animations, compositing, and special effects for film, video, and digital media.

technical barriers, enabling students to focus on narrative experimentation. Basic interaction logic such as on-hover and on-click triggers are handled through these scripts, while Unity's Animator system introduces students to real-time node-based animation workflows. Students are encouraged to expand upon the mechanics if they wish to push the project's technical and creative boundaries.

The decision to retain the interactive collage assessment was reinforced by its impact on students' academic trajectories. A notable example is alumna Bea Ellis, who initially intended to specialise in animation but discovered a passion for interactive media through this project. The accessible, exploratory nature of the collage prompted her to shift into the game design pathway and later informed her third-year capstone project. Cases like this demonstrate the assessment's capacity to reveal and cultivate emerging interests, validating its continued inclusion within the redesigned curriculum.

These pedagogical outcomes, where animation and interactivity are interwoven, align with the core principles of the integrated design practice framework. Despite broader structural changes to the degree, the project continues to offer students a familiar and approachable entry point into interactive media while supporting cross-disciplinary modes of cultural and creative expression. In doing so, it equips students with foundational literacy in designing responsive digital environments and underscores the role of animation, visual effects, and game design as a site for emergent storytelling and artistic experimentation.

Importantly, skills learned while creating their animations, Unity interactions, and film compositing prepare students for industry trends that increasingly value hybrid workflows, rapid prototyping¹⁹, and creative problem-solving across platforms. Stop motion fosters an understanding of frame-by-frame animation principles with tactile storytelling, which remain relevant in both independent and commercial animation contexts. Unity, as an industry-standard engine, introduces students to real-time rendering, interactivity, and cross-platform deployment, skills that are in high demand across animation, VFX, and game development sectors.

2.4 Fostering Identity and Inclusion through creative icebreakers

In the early weeks of the semester, we introduce activities (icebreakers) designed to foster connection, inclusion, and a sense of belonging. The icebreakers are intentional pedagogical tools that support students in forming relationships, expressing identity, and feeling seen. The emphasis on connection and preservation of identity aligns with our commitment to Mātauranga Māori, recognising the importance of whakapapa, place, and personal narrative in shaping learning experiences.

AVG is increasingly attracting a wide spectrum of learners, with a noticeable rise in neurodivergent students. Those with ADHD, autism, dyslexia, and other cognitive differences bring unique perspectives and new problem-solving approaches to the classroom. The shift reflects a broader commitment to inclusive education and a recognition that diversity in thinking styles enhances creative outcomes. Alongside this, the student body continues to grow

in cultural, socioeconomic, and disciplinary diversity, creating a vibrant learning environment where cross-pollination of ideas is encouraged.

Many students are bright, enthusiastic, ambitious, and deeply creative. However, they also grapple with challenges such as imposter syndrome, perfectionism, and the pressure to constantly innovate. These emotional and psychological hurdles are addressed through a culture that prioritises empathy, transparency, and peer support. Signs of burnout and disengagement are actively recognised, and informal check-ins are embedded into studio practice to ensure students feel heard and valued.

2.4.1 Yarn Yarn. The *Yarn Yarn* (Figure 3) begins with a student holding a ball of yarn and responding to a prompt such as, "What did you get up to over summer?" or "Why did you choose to come to AUT?" As the yarn is passed from person to person, a visible web forms, symbolising the growing network of relationships within the cohort. Once everyone is connected, the yarn is carefully unrolled, with each student sharing something they hope to learn or gain from their time at AUT.

This activity is grounded in the pedagogical principles outlined by Crystal Higgs [Higgs, 2013]. Higgs emphasises the importance of "showing your face" and "sharing your intentions" as foundational steps in building trust and connection. In our adaptation, *Yarn Yarn* asks both students and lecturers to model openness, reinforcing connection between learners and educators. This reciprocal exchange helps break down perceived barriers, allowing students to see their lecturers as real people with experiences and aspirations. Higgs also highlights the power of shared connections and personal choice in learning, both of which are embedded in the structure of *Yarn Yarn*, particularly during the un-weaving phase.

This moment allows us to listen closely, understand students' individual goals, and begin identifying which pathway - animation, visual effects, or game design, they are most drawn to. *Yarn Yarn* sets a tone of openness and shared purpose and serves as a tactile metaphor for the interconnectedness of the AVG disciplines. This activity is a reminder that every student's voice matters. By leading the activity ourselves and modelling vulnerability, we create a space where students feel safe to participate and be seen.

2.4.2 Plasticine Portraits. Plasticine Portraits (Figure 4) invites students to work in pairs and ask each other a series of getting-to-know-you questions. Based on their partner's responses, each student sculpts an object from plasticine that symbolises something meaningful, and gifts it to their partner.

This tactile and playful exchange encourages self-reflection, empathy, and creative expression, helping students begin to establish their place within the AUT learning community. It also provides a much-needed step away from the computer, offering a hands-on medium through which students can engage with their peers in a relaxed and inclusive environment.

Following the activity, students are invited to reflect in their digital workbooks through an annotation task, considering what they learned about their cohort and how the experience shaped their understanding of identity and connection.

¹⁹Rapid prototyping is quick generation of early versions or models, used to test ideas, gather feedback, and refine concepts before full development.



Figure 3: First year students participating in the Yarn Yarn activity



Figure 4: Collection of first year student plasticine portraits

2.5 Rubric and Grading

Where conventional standardised testing models prioritise a single outcome, assessment in DESN511 and DESN512 foregrounds the creative journey. Final outputs are evaluated alongside the decisions, reflections, and iterations that shape them, enabling students to grow as emerging designers through supported experimentation rather than polished perfection. Both courses integrate formative checkpoints with summative submissions to foster creative confidence, technical skill, and reflective practice. Clear expectations guide students' documentation, production, and engagement with course themes. In DESN512, students submit a formative workbook with six weekly annotations responding to guided reflective prompts, followed by a summative package comprising a Unity-based interactive collage, finalised workbook, and twelve annotations.

The interactive piece must represent a pivotal moment linked to personal life, culture, or identity. Provided scripts (e.g., onhover, onclick) reduce technical barriers, allowing students to focus on narrative and interactivity. In DESN511, students produce a short film exploring the relationship between a local water source, a nostalgic object, and personal identity, using stop-motion and greenscreen

compositing. Supporting artefacts - including a 'making-of' video, weekly annotations, a written reflection, and a title card, document the evolution of ideas across the project timeline. Both courses are anchored in the Bachelor of Design programme's core criteria, offering a holistic framework for assessing creative capability (see Table 1).

Assessment therefore extends beyond the quality of the final artefact to encompass the creative journey itself, students' ability to document process, respond to critique, reflect on decisions, and iterate with purpose. Structured requirements around file formatting, annotation, and self-reflection support the development of culturally aware, practice-led designers who can articulate both what they have produced and the rationale behind their creative choices.

The choice of these teaching strategies is informed not only by anecdotal case studies but also by student feedback and broader pedagogical research. Laurillard, 2013 emphasises the importance of iterative dialogue between teacher and learner, where conceptual understanding is developed through cycles of practice, feedback, and reflection. This model supports the use of scaffolded, exploratory projects that allow students to test ideas, receive formative feedback, and refine their creative and technical approaches.

2.6 Case Study: *Sinking* (Maria Parson)

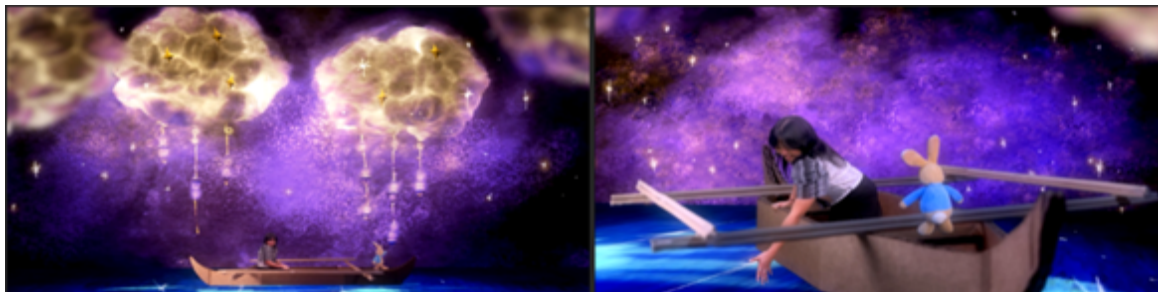
Maria Parsons' short film *Sinking* (Figure 5) for DESN511 explores resilience and emotional growth through the metaphor of dishwashing in a commercial kitchen. Her chosen water source, the kitchen sink, is tied to personal memories and identity. The nostalgic object, a plate animated with food scraps, serves as a stop motion component representing childhood and maternal connection. The film features a surreal sink-world sequence created using green screen and parallax effects in After Effects, blending live action, stop motion, and compositing techniques. Maria's use of colour grading, camera angles, and visual metaphors enhances the emotional tone of the narrative, demonstrating the expressive potential of VFX in storytelling. Her project reflects the core aims of the Wai Horotiu brief, combining technical experimentation with personal reflection. Teaching methods such as guided reflection on identity, prompted annotations and the hikoi, for example, encouraged Maria to engage deeply with her whakapapa and emotional landscape, fostering resilience through self-awareness and narrative agency. By situating her work within a framework of cultural and emotional inquiry, Maria's film allows them to develop technical skills and grow their awareness of applying storytelling to articulate their perspective.

2.7 Case Study: *Home is where the heart is* (Kyra Baul)

Kyra Balbuena's short film (Figure 6) for DESN511 explores themes of identity, nostalgia, and cultural connection through a dreamlike narrative set between Half Moon Bay Marina and the Philippine Sea. The project integrates stop motion animation of a childhood toy, green screen compositing, and surreal visual effects to depict a personal journey of homesickness and belonging. Kyra used After Effects and Premiere Pro to blend live action, animated elements, and hand-crafted sets, applying techniques such as parallax, chroma

Table 1: Grading rubric guiding principles

Principle	Description	Weight
Motuhaketanga (Self-reflexivity)	Self-reflexivity is demonstrated by the student's independent and purposeful design curiosity, questioning, perceptiveness, and critical reflection.	20pts
Maakitanga (Professionalism)	Professionalism is shown in the student's practical application of personal design ethics and values evident in their project proposal, discussions and outcome(s).	20pts
Auahatanga (Conceptual and contextual positioning)	Evidence of integration of critical theoretical concepts, contexts, and precedents, tangible and intangible knowledge from across a student's chosen specialisms.	20pts
Pūkenga (Methods in context)	Applying fundamental methods, media, and technologies with awareness	20pts
Kōrero pono (Communication)	The student's contextual and conceptual knowledge, methods, and integrated design practice outcome(s) are professionally synthesised and effectively communicated	20pts

**Figure 5: Maria Parsons' "Sinking", exploring the integration of stop motion and live action****Figure 6: Kyra Balbuena project demonstrates compositing techniques**

keying, and colour grading to create a cohesive and emotionally resonant film. Her work demonstrates the expressive potential of VFX in storytelling and reflects the core aims of the Wai Horotiu brief.

2.8 Case Study: Childhood Bedroom (Sienna Hargreaves)

Sienna Hargreaves's interactive collage Childhood Bedroom (Figure 7) for DESN512 reflects identity and self-expression through the metaphor of their adolescent bedroom. Once bare due to insecurity, space gradually fills with objects and imagery as confidence grows, embodying the shift toward self-acceptance. The project combines



Figure 7: Sienna Hargreave's interactive collage explored technical aspects beyond what was required of the brief

layered animations and original coding, extending interactivity beyond the brief's requirements. Subtle horror motifs are embedded within the domestic setting, aligning with the student's interest in "sweet horror", unsettling elements hidden behind innocence. The result is a technically ambitious and thematically intimate exploration of place and identity.

2.9 Staffing, New Students and Class Sizes

Student numbers in the AVG programme have more than doubled over the past decade, prompting increased staffing and pedagogical adaptation. This growth reflects the programme's interdisciplinary appeal and its emphasis on storytelling, design thinking, and creative problem-solving.

Currently, ten full-time and nine casual staff support the programme. Teaching is collaborative and adaptive, with staff rotating across modules to offer diverse perspectives. Clear communication around staff expertise fosters targeted mentorship and learner autonomy. Teaching Assistants and Peer Mentors help manage growing class sizes and provide timely support. To maintain engagement, staff use rotation systems and peer-led critique formats (such as Crits and Pitch Session), that promote equitable feedback and critical reflection. Common questions are addressed collectively, streamlining communication and encouraging student independence.

Students also maintain a peer-led Discord community, where they interpret briefs, troubleshoot software, and support one another. This eases pressure on staff while fostering leadership and resilience. Space remains a challenge, with labs often at capacity. Flexible timetabling and hybrid models are being explored to improve access and responsiveness.

2.10 Anecdotal Response from Students

Anecdotal responses from students have provided valuable insights into how the structure and delivery of the AVG major resonate with learners. These reflections have directly influenced the way we craft project briefs, our pedagogical workflow and embedded design practice, across the three pathways.

In terms of pathway resonance, students consistently express appreciation for the distinct pathways offered within the AVG major. The specialisations allow individuals to align their studies with personal interests and career aspirations, encouraging engagement and ownership of their learning. Pathway options are a defining feature of the major, due to the availability of multiple specialisations and are frequently cited by students as a key attraction of the programme. There is an appeal for specialising, while fostering a cohort culture that supports overlaps of discussion with sharing core

pipeline stages. For example, these include concept development, pre-visualisation, asset creation, and post-production. These stages support a flexible pedagogical framework across preproduction, production, and postproduction, while allowing each discipline to explore its own technical and creative depth. To meet the specific demands of each pathway, project briefs and learning outcomes are also customised accordingly based on student feedback.

3 Conclusion and future directions

The AVG curriculum at AUT positions animation, visual effects, and game design as interconnected modes of creative expression, each introduced early to support student exploration and pathway selection. Animation serves as a foundational language, visual effects offer a gateway to visual storytelling, and game design provides a framework for interactive expression. This early integration across DESN511 and DESN512 allows students to experiment with multiple disciplines while beginning to identify their individual interests and strengths.

The curriculum balances creative freedom with the development of foundational skills, supported by culturally responsive pedagogy. Activities such as Yarn Yarn and Plasticine Portraits foster inclusion, connection, and identity formation, aligning with the principles of Mātauranga Māori and the Bachelor of Design. These tactile, relational experiences help students feel seen, heard, and supported as they begin their creative journeys.

Looking ahead, future curriculum development should consider scalability, interdisciplinary resource sharing, and the evolving interests of students. As learners engage with Animation, Visual Effects, and Game Design in their first year, they gain exposure to a broad spectrum of creative practices, laying the groundwork for integrated design thinking. This foundation enables meaningful cross-disciplinary collaboration, particularly in capstone projects where students can form groups across specialisations to reflect the collaborative nature of the creative industries. By continuing to centre identity, collaboration, and creative inquiry, the AVG programme can remain responsive, inclusive, and relevant in a rapidly changing design landscape. This integrated approach not only supports diverse learner pathways but also reinforces the value of combining disciplines to foster innovation, collaboration and cultural relevance in design education.

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